Q+A

Entering Alien Territory

Adarsh Gourav has a juicy part in the latest edition of the *Alien* series, streaming on JioHotstar now

Q. *Alien* is an iconic franchise and Noah Hawley a top writer-director on streaming thanks to *Fargo*. Tell us how *Alien: Earth* happened.
For the past 2-3 years, I have been auditioning for parts in LA and London. I kept getting shortlisted, but nothing converted. When *Alien* went through rounds two and three of the audition and my agents said Noah wants to speak with me, I still wasn't thinking about getting it. When he called and said he was a fan of my work in *The White Tiger*, I didn't know what to say. He then offered me the part of Slightly. Next thing I knew I was in Bangkok shooting for six months.

Q. Are you a sci-fi geek?
Honestly, I wasn't, but now I am. I had only watched a few mainstream films, including Ridley Scott's *Alien*, when I was a child. When I got the part, I also watched the James Cameron and David Fincher versions and read about the entire universe. Otherwise, it'd be embarrassing if I went on set and just sat there clueless. After all I was also representing my country.

Q. The beauty of a good project in the genre is how pertinent it can be to the present. Is *Alien: Earth* doing that for you?
Absolutely. Noah is putting a giant-sized mirror in front of the audience to make them look at who they are, what they have done and what they are capable of. For me, it is a reflection of the direction society is heading in—and it's dangerous.

Q. It's your first international gig since *The White Tiger*. What do you hope it accomplishes?
I have been waiting in the wings for something like this. I am hungry to do better work and with directors who I respect and love, and who inspire me. The *Alien* IP and having Noah Hawley on board could hopefully help me get more exciting stuff in future.

—with Suhani Singh

Photograph by HARDIK CHHABRA